

The Deck

The afternoon sun cut across the backyard in long, golden angles. Josh pulled into the driveway after his half-day shift, still wearing the dust of irrigation work on his clothes. He expected a quiet house, maybe his dad inside watching something on television. Instead, he found Kevin on the back patio, measuring and cutting two-by-fours with the kind of focused precision that made it look effortless.

A deck was taking shape. No warning. No planning meetings or sketches left on the kitchen table. Just Kevin, deciding his family needed a deck, and building it.

Josh didn't ask questions. He set down his bag and grabbed a pair of work gloves from the garage. Kevin glanced over, nodded once, and they fell into the rhythm they'd known their whole lives — the language of fathers and sons who fix things. Kevin would position a board, and Josh would know where to hold it. Kevin would call for the level, and Josh was already reaching for it. No words necessary. This was how they talked.

The sun dropped lower as they worked. Sweat darkened their shirts. Kevin's hands moved with the confidence of a man who'd built a thousand things, and Josh watched those hands the way he always did — learning, always learning. By the time the last board was secured and the final nail driven home, the sky had turned that peculiar shade of orange that only happens in late afternoon.

Kevin stepped back, surveying the deck. He smiled — the kind of smile that meant he was satisfied, that it was good. Josh felt that smile like a gift.

Neither of them knew this would be one of the last things they built together.

The waiting room of the oncology clinic was aggressively neutral. Beige walls. Soft lighting designed to be calming but somehow made everything feel worse. Josh sat beside his father, still not entirely sure why they were here. Kevin had mentioned a doctor's appointment. Josh had asked if he should come. Kevin had said yes, so Josh came.

The nurse called them back. A young doctor with tired eyes gestured them into an examination room that was somehow even more sterile than the waiting area. Kevin sat on the paper-covered table. Josh stood against the wall, hands in his pockets.

The doctor didn't make small talk. He opened a folder and delivered the words the way you'd deliver a package — efficiently, without flourish. Pancreatic cancer. Advanced. Five to seven months.

Josh's mind went white.

Kevin's face didn't change much. He'd always been good at taking bad news the way he took everything else — head on, without flinching.

Josh opened his mouth. Words came out, but they weren't words. They were sounds filling empty space, noise to cover the screaming in his head. He talked about treatment options he didn't understand. He asked questions that made no sense. He was fumbling, desperate, trying to say something that mattered when everything had just collapsed into five to seven months.

Kevin listened to his son stumble through those meaningless words and said nothing. He just listened.

The drive home was silent. Josh kept both hands on the wheel, staring at the road ahead like it might give him answers. Kevin stared out the passenger window at the city passing by — Spokane in all its ordinary afternoon glory, completely indifferent to what had just happened in that beige room.

Josh's mind was spiraling through futures that no longer existed. College funds for the girls. Stability. Time. His father teaching his granddaughters how to fix things the way he'd taught Josh. All of it evaporating into five to seven months.

"Your mother would've hated that doctor," Kevin said suddenly, his voice casual in a way that made it hurt worse.

Josh didn't respond. He couldn't. His throat was tight.

"She would've asked a thousand questions. Made him explain everything twice. Probably would've argued with him about the prognosis." Kevin smiled slightly, still looking out the window. "She was something else."

Josh had been two when his mother died. He barely remembered her, only what Kevin had told him over the years. Stories. Fragments. But in this moment, he felt her absence like a fresh wound.

"You're gonna be okay," Kevin said. It wasn't a question. It was a statement of fact, the same way he'd always spoken about things — like saying it made it true.

Josh wanted to believe him. He wanted to believe that somehow, in five to seven months, everything would still be okay.

He was learning, in that moment, that wanting and believing weren't the same thing.

The first month was a blur of appointments and adjustments. Kevin started chemotherapy. Josh watched his father's body betray him in increments — the hair going first, then the weight, then something less visible but more profound: the energy that had always defined him beginning to dim.

Josh tried to be there. He took time off work when he could. He sat in waiting rooms. He drove his father to treatments. But there was a problem he couldn't solve with tools or effort: he was disappearing into it all, and his own family was noticing.

Kimberly would ask him questions and he wouldn't hear them. Paisleigh wanted to show him something and he was already somewhere else — in a hospital room, in a prognosis, in five to seven months that were ticking down whether he paid attention or not. Brielle, seven years old and sharp, asked once why daddy was sad all the time now.

Josh didn't have an answer for her.

The fighting with Kimberly started small. A comment about him being gone again. A sigh when he said he had to go help his dad with something. Then bigger things — accusations that he didn't care anymore, that his father mattered more than they did. Josh knew it wasn't fair, but he also couldn't stop. His father was dying. How was he supposed to act normal about that?

By week six, the tension in the house had become its own living thing, breathing in the spaces between them.

That's when Trish called.

Josh almost didn't answer. The number was unfamiliar, and he was exhausted. But something made him pick up.

"Hey," a woman's voice said. "It's Trish. Your sister."

Josh blinked. He hadn't heard from Trish in years. Decades, maybe. She'd been a peripheral figure in his childhood — Kevin's daughter from before Josh was born, someone who'd chosen a different life, a life that didn't include much contact with Kevin or Josh.

"Trish?"

"Yeah. I... I heard about Dad. I heard he's sick."

Josh didn't remember telling her. He didn't remember anyone telling her. But news travels, and apparently it had traveled all the way to Idaho.

"Yeah," Josh said slowly. "He is."

There was a pause on the line. When Trish spoke again, her voice had softened. "I want to help. I know I haven't been around, but... he's still my dad. Can I come?"

Josh should have seen it then. Should have heard something in her tone that didn't add up. But he was too tired, too scared, too desperate for anyone to share the weight.

"Yeah," he said. "Come."

Trish arrived on a Saturday morning in a car that looked like it had been driven straight from Idaho without stopping. She was polite. Professional, almost. She hugged Kevin carefully, like she was afraid he might break. She brought groceries. She asked what needed doing.

Within a week, she was there every other day. By the second week, she was there almost daily.

Josh watched her slip into their lives like she'd always been there. She drove Kevin to appointments. She cleaned the house. She sat with him during treatments while Josh was at work, because someone had to keep the bills paid. Someone had to pretend everything was normal enough to function.

Kimberly noticed it before Josh did. "Your sister's really stepping up," she said one evening, and there was something in her tone — not quite accusation, but close. Josh was too grateful for the help to hear the warning underneath.

Trish became indispensable. That was the word Kevin used once, talking to Josh about how grateful he was. "She's been indispensable," he said, and Josh felt a flutter of something he didn't recognize. Relief, maybe. Guilt that he couldn't be there more. Gratitude that someone was.

What Josh didn't know — what he wouldn't know for weeks — was that Trish was doing more than helping. She was positioning herself. Quietly, carefully, during moments when Josh was at work and Kevin was vulnerable and tired from treatment, she was

rewriting the future.

She brought papers to sign. Legal documents. She framed them as protection, as planning ahead, as making sure things were in order. Kevin, exhausted and frightened and trying to be practical about his own mortality, signed them.

By the time the cancer took Kevin's life — five months and three weeks after that beige office and the word "pancreatic" — Trish had already stolen everything.

Josh just didn't know it yet.

Hospice had set up the bed that morning. Kevin lay in it like a man who'd finally stopped fighting, his body small beneath the blankets, diminished by months of treatment and time running out.

Josh sat beside him. They didn't talk much at first — what was there to say? But as the afternoon faded into evening, Kevin's eyes found his son's, and something shifted.

"Hey, bud," Kevin said, his voice thin but steady. "I'm sorry I let you down."

Josh felt the words like a punch. "What? Dad, no. You never—"

Kevin said nothing. He just looked at his son, and whatever he'd meant to say, he didn't say it.

Josh wanted to push, wanted to ask what his father meant, but something about the look on Kevin's face stopped him. So he let it sit there, unanswered, and reached over to take his father's hand instead.

They fell into a different kind of silence after that — the kind that doesn't need filling. And then, as the room dimmed into evening, they started talking. Really talking. About everything that mattered and everything that didn't. Josh told his father things he'd never said out loud. Kevin told Josh he was proud of him, that raising him had been the best thing he'd ever done with his life. They laughed about old memories — the deck, the warehouse, the thousand small repairs Kevin had turned into lessons over the years. They didn't cry much. They just talked, the way men like Kevin and Josh talked — plainly, honestly, without performance.

By the time the windows started to lighten with the first edge of dawn, there was nothing left unsaid between them. Josh felt wrung out and complete at the same time, like something important had finally been finished.

He fell asleep on the couch beside the bed sometime after sunrise, his hand still loosely holding his father's.

When he woke a few hours later, the light in the room had changed. Kevin's hand was cold in his.

Sometime while Josh slept, his father had simply stopped.

Josh sat with his father's body for a long time. He didn't call anyone right away. He didn't know what to do with the silence in the room, the stillness where there used to be breathing, where there used to be his dad. He just sat there, holding a hand that wasn't holding back anymore.

Eventually he made the calls he had to make. Hospice. The coroner. The people who knew how to handle the practical machinery of death. Numb, hollowed out, Josh moved through the motions of a morning he never wanted to live.

It was barely past noon when Trish's car pulled into the driveway.

Josh hadn't called her. He didn't know how she'd found out so fast, didn't have the energy to wonder. She came up the walk with her boyfriend trailing a step behind her, and her face wore an expression Josh would later understand was rehearsed — sympathy worn like a costume.

"Josh," she said softly, pulling him into a hug he didn't have the strength to resist. "I'm so sorry."

He let himself be held. He was too exhausted, too raw, to notice that her eyes weren't red, that she hadn't been crying, that her grief looked nothing like his.

"We thought maybe you'd want to get out of the house for a bit," she said. "Get some breakfast. Talk."

Josh nodded. The house felt unbearable, full of his father's absence in every corner. Getting out, even with Trish, even with the stranger she'd brought, felt like the only thing he could manage.

He didn't know, as he climbed into the back of her car, that he was being led away on purpose. That somewhere across town, a courtroom was waiting, and Trish had timed this perfectly.

The diner was the kind of place Kevin used to take Josh as a kid — vinyl booths, laminated menus, coffee that never stopped being refilled. Trish ordered for the table like she'd done it a hundred times. Her boyfriend made easy conversation, the kind designed to keep a grieving man's mind occupied without actually saying anything.

"Dad loved you so much," Trish said at one point, reaching across the table to squeeze Josh's hand. "He talked about you constantly. You were everything to him."

Josh nodded, throat tight. He didn't trust his voice.

Somewhere between the eggs and the second cup of coffee, the conversation shifted.

"There's some paperwork we need from the house," Trish said, casual, like it was an afterthought. "Just legal stuff. Financial documents. To get everything sorted properly."

"Yeah," Josh said. "Of course."

"And the firearms," her boyfriend added, not quite meeting Josh's eyes. "With the girls in the house — Paisleigh, Brielle — it's probably not safe to have them around right now. We can hold onto them. Just for safekeeping."

Josh felt a flicker of something almost like gratitude. They were thinking about his daughters. They were being responsible, careful, the way family was supposed to be.

He didn't see it for what it was. He couldn't have. Grief doesn't leave room for suspicion.

By the time they dropped him back home that afternoon, Josh had handed over documents, keys, access. He'd helped them load the guns into the trunk of Trish's car himself.

It was three days later when Ron called.

Ron's voice on the phone was warm, familiar — the kind of voice that belonged to someone who'd known you since you were a kid hanging around your dad's workplace, swiping snacks from the break room.

"Hey, Josh," Ron said. "I heard about your dad. I'm so sorry, son. He was a good man. The best."

Josh managed a quiet thanks.

"I was wondering if I could come by," Ron continued. "Just sit with you a while. Talk about him. Your dad and I worked together damn near twenty years. I've got stories you probably never heard."

It sounded good. It sounded like exactly what Josh needed — someone who'd known Kevin as a man, a coworker, a friend, not just as "dad." Someone who could help fill in the parts of his father's life Josh hadn't been there for.

"Yeah," Josh said. "Come by."

Ron showed up that afternoon with a six-pack and an easy smile, and for a few hours, Josh got to sit and listen to stories about his father — the time Kevin rebuilt an entire forklift engine over a weekend just because he said he could, the way he never let anyone leave the warehouse without making sure they got home safe, the legend of the man everybody respected. Josh laughed. He cried a little. It felt, for the first time since the hospice bed, like something good.

He didn't know that Trish had called Ron three days earlier. Didn't know the visit had been arranged, timed, weaponized as a distraction.

Later that evening, after Ron left, Josh sat at the kitchen table with his laptop, doing something he did out of habit more than worry. He was on probation — had been for over a year — and he liked to check the county court website periodically, just to make sure nothing had slipped through, no missed check-in had turned into a bench warrant he didn't know about.

He typed his own name into the search bar, the way he always did.

What came back wasn't a probation hearing.

It was a probate filing. A hearing. That same afternoon. His father's name. His own name, listed as an interested party who hadn't appeared. And Trish's name, listed as petitioner, requesting to be named executor of Kevin's estate.

Josh read it three times before it made sense.

While Ron had been sitting in his living room telling stories about Kevin, Trish had been in a courtroom across town, finalizing what she'd already spent months arranging. The breakfast. The paperwork. The guns. Ron's visit. All of it — every kindness, every gesture — had been a piece of something Josh hadn't even known he was inside of.

He sat there in the kitchen, the laptop screen glowing in the dark, and felt something inside him go quiet and cold.

Josh tried calling her that night. Straight to voicemail. He tried again the next morning. Same result. By the afternoon, he'd convinced Kimberly to try — maybe Trish would answer for someone who wasn't Josh, someone calmer, someone who hadn't just found out his entire inheritance was gone.

Kimberly got through. Barely.

"Trish, it's Kimberly. Josh's wife. We just want to understand what's going on, we're not trying to—"

"My lawyer has advised me not to speak with you," Trish said, flat and rehearsed, and hung up.

That was it. That was the entire conversation. No explanation. No acknowledgment of the house, the vehicles, the camper, the five hundred thousand dollars that had quietly funneled itself into her name while Josh sat in waiting rooms and clocked hours at work to keep food on the table. Just a lawyer's sentence, recited like a shield.

A week later, papers arrived. A no-contact order. Trish had gone to a court and claimed she needed protection from her own brother — a man who had never raised a hand to her, never raised his voice, never done anything except call her when their father got sick and ask her to help.

Josh read the order standing in his driveway, the paper shaking slightly in his hands, though there was no wind.

He had handed over keys and guns and trust to a woman who had been planning his erasure the entire time he thought she was helping. And now, legally, he wasn't even allowed to ask her why.

There would be no confrontation. No moment where he got to stand across from her and demand an answer. No courtroom drama where the truth came out and justice arrived to set things right.

There would only be silence. Hers, permanent and chosen. His, forced and absolute.

Trish had gotten away with it. Cleanly. Completely. And somewhere in Idaho, she was living in a house that should have been his, driving vehicles that should have been his, sitting on money that should have built a future for two little girls who didn't yet understand what had been stolen from them.

Josh just had to find a way to keep breathing through it.

The weeks that followed blurred together. Josh went through the motions of work — irrigation lines, sprinkler heads, the mechanical rhythm of a job that had nothing to do with grief or betrayal but demanded his attention anyway. He showed up. He did the work. But something in him had gone numb, and numb men make mistakes.

He missed a service call. Then another. His supervisor, a reasonable man who'd given him slack for the months of distraction while Kevin was sick, finally ran out of patience. Josh was let go on a Thursday, standing in a gravel parking lot with a final paycheck and nothing else.

He didn't fight it. He didn't have the fight left in him.

At home, things weren't better. Kimberly tried, in the beginning. She asked questions. She tried to get him to talk about Trish, about Kevin, about any of it. But Josh had nothing to give her. Everything he had was being spent just staying upright, just getting through each day without collapsing under the weight of what had happened.

He stopped reaching for her at night. Stopped really hearing her when she talked. Paisleigh would toddle up to him with some toy, some small offering of a two-year-old's love, and Josh would smile at her, but it was a smile from somewhere far away.

Brielle noticed more than anyone. She was seven, old enough to read a room, old enough to know that her father had changed into someone quieter, someone who flinched at sudden noises and stared at nothing for long stretches of time. She stopped asking him to play. She just watched him, the way kids watch storms — from a careful distance, waiting to see what happens next.

The fighting between Josh and Kimberly stopped being about small things and became about everything. Money, now nonexistent without his income. Time, which Josh seemed incapable of giving anyone, including himself. The growing distance that neither of them knew how to close. They said things to each other they couldn't take back — not because they meant them, but because they didn't know how else to release the pressure building inside two people drowning in the same house.

Without the job, without the inheritance that was supposed to be a safety net, there was nothing left to catch them. The mortgage went unpaid. The savings ran out. What Josh had believed would be a foundation — a paid-off house, reliable vehicles, security for his daughters — had evaporated into Trish's hands, and what remained was a family standing on nothing.

The eviction notice came on a gray Tuesday, taped to a door that no longer felt like it belonged to them. Josh stood reading it in the same driveway where he'd once read a no-contact order with shaking hands. He'd run out of ways to be surprised by his own life.

They had thirty days. Thirty days to find somewhere else to be a family, except by then, Josh wasn't sure they were a family anymore. The fighting had become a constant hum beneath everything, sometimes quiet, sometimes loud enough that Brielle would take Paisleigh into her room and shut the door, the two of them sitting together while their parents tore at each other in the kitchen.

Kimberly started looking at apartments. Small ones, places that could maybe fit her and the girls. She never said the words out loud — never said *I'm leaving* — but Josh could feel it in the careful way she'd started talking about logistics, about school districts, about things that didn't include him in the sentence.

And yet she didn't leave. Not then.

Josh would ask himself later why she stayed as long as she did, through the worst of it, through the version of him that had nothing left to offer her. He didn't have an answer except that maybe some part of her was still waiting for the man she'd married to come back. Maybe she couldn't make herself do that to him — pack up the girls and disappear — without knowing he'd survive it.

But staying didn't mean trying. They picked fights instead of conversations. They found reasons to be in separate rooms, separate cars, separate lives under the same disintegrating roof. It was cruelty born from exhaustion, two people who'd once loved each other now just trying to survive each other.

When the thirty days ran out, there was no apartment waiting, no plan, no family unit moving forward together. There was just Josh, alone, with a duffel bag and nowhere to be.

He found a men's group home through a referral — a place built for guys exactly like him, men who'd lost everything and needed somewhere structured to rebuild from. Clean. Sober. Accountable. It wasn't a home. It was a foundation, or the attempt at one.

Kimberly took the girls to stay with her mother. Josh told himself it was temporary. He told himself a lot of things during those first weeks in the group home, lying on a twin bed in a room that wasn't his, listening to other men's stories of how they'd ended up there too.

Everyone had a Trish. Everyone had a moment where the floor disappeared.

Josh just hadn't expected his to come with so much love wrapped around the betrayal.

The group home gave Josh structure he didn't know he'd been missing. Curfews. Chores. Mandatory meetings where men sat in a circle and said true things out loud, sometimes for the first time in their lives. Josh wasn't good at the talking part. He sat through most of those meetings with his jaw tight, listening more than sharing, but something about being surrounded by other men clawing their way back from their own collapses made the weight a little more bearable.

He got a part-time job almost immediately — staining cabinets for a small contracting outfit a few miles from the home. It wasn't much, but it was something, and something was more than he'd had in months. There was a strange comfort in the work, too — his hands moving over wood the way his father's once had, rubbing stain into grain until it came alive. It was the closest thing to Kevin he had left.

The trouble started with his roommate, a guy named Grant who'd been at the home longer than Josh and seemed to have decided early on that Josh's quiet was something to needle at. Small things at first — comments about Josh keeping to himself, about him thinking he was better than everyone else. Then bigger things. Stolen food from the shared fridge. A confrontation in the hallway that nearly turned physical before staff intervened.

The house coordinator gave Josh a choice that wasn't really a choice: find somewhere else, or risk losing his spot entirely if things escalated again. Josh packed his bag for the second time in four months.

His aunt — Kevin's sister, a woman named Karen who Josh hadn't spent much time with growing up — offered to take him in. "Family helps family," she told him on the phone, and Josh, starved for anything resembling the family he'd lost, said yes.

The first few weeks were good. Karen fed him, gave him a room, asked about Kevin in a way that felt like grieving together instead of grieving alone. The holidays came and went in her small house, and for a moment, Josh let himself believe he'd found solid ground again.

But Karen had her own life, her own patterns, and Josh — still raw, still struggling to hold himself together — wasn't always easy to live with. Small tensions became bigger ones. Karen started making comments about how long he planned to stay. About contributing more. About him needing to "figure his life out" instead of leaning on her.

By February, Josh was packing again.

This time it was Melanie — an ex-girlfriend from years before Kimberly, someone he'd reconnected with through a mutual friend during one of his lowest stretches. She offered him her couch, no strings, just kindness from someone who remembered who he used to be. Josh stayed with her for a few months, grateful and embarrassed in equal measure.

But the fighting with Kimberly didn't stop just because Josh had moved out. Custody conversations, money conversations, conversations that always ended in raised voices over the phone while Melanie sat in the next room pretending not to hear. Eventually, the tension bled into Melanie's space too, and she gently, kindly, asked him to find somewhere else.

Josh didn't blame her. He was starting to understand that he carried his own storm with him, no matter where he landed.

After Melanie's, there were a few more couches. A few more weeks here, a month there. Josh stopped counting addresses after a while — it felt like keeping score of his own failure. What he didn't stop doing was working.

The cabinet-staining job led to a recommendation, which led to an interview at the top-rated auto detailing shop in Spokane, a place with a six-week waiting list and a reputation that meant something in the industry. Josh got hired on a trial basis and never looked back. He was good at it — meticulous, patient, the kind of careful precision his father had drilled into him without either of them realizing it was a gift. Within a year, he was full-time, trusted with the cars that mattered most, the ones owners babied like children.

He was thriving, by every measure that didn't include a roof of his own.

Eighteen months had passed since he'd seen Paisleigh and Brielle. Eighteen months of birthdays he wasn't invited to, of school years he heard about secondhand if he heard about them at all. Kimberly had pulled the girls into her orbit completely, and the version of Josh that existed in their lives now was a man whose name Brielle, at nine, might still remember, and whose face Paisleigh, at four, might not.

Josh had built himself back from nothing. Stable job. Stable income. A clear head, most days. And still, none of it filled the specific, aching absence of his daughters.

He'd met Brittany — Brit, to everyone who knew her — a little over a year ago, through a mutual friend named Bobby. She was steady in a way Josh hadn't experienced in years. Patient with the parts of him that were still healing. With no access to his daughters, with that entire chamber of his heart sealed off and untouchable, Josh had poured everything he had into her instead. All his time. All his attention. It was the only relationship he had left to give himself to.

Then, on an ordinary Wednesday, his phone rang with a number he didn't recognize.

It was CPS.

They were investigating Kimberly. Twenty-one separate allegations, spanning months, involving Paisleigh and Brielle. Neglect. Possible abuse. Josh sat in his car in the shop's parking lot, gripping the phone, hearing details about his daughters' lives that no father should learn secondhand from a stranger reading off a case file.

It was the first he'd heard of any of it.

And buried inside the horror of it — guilt that he hadn't been there, fury that he hadn't known — was something else entirely. An opening. The CPS worker explained that, pending further investigation, Josh had the right to request supervised visitation.

For the first time in eighteen months, Josh was going to see his daughters again.

It didn't feel like victory. It felt like a door cracking open in a wall he'd thought was permanent, light spilling through a gap he'd given up hoping existed. Two years of grief, theft, homelessness, and silence, and somehow, here was a thread leading back to Paisleigh and Brielle — frayed, complicated, born out of someone else's failure instead of any justice of his own.

Josh didn't know yet how he'd hold both things at once — the relationship with Brit he'd built his entire identity around for the past year, and the daughters who were suddenly, finally, within reach again.

He only knew he wasn't going to let this door close without walking through it.